maker Micron Technology is coming up with its maiden manufacturing facility in India with an investment of Rs 22,500 crore, which is expected to generate 20,000 jobs by 2025. GIFT City, meanwhile, has 550-plus operational entities offering over 26,000 jobs.

But in Shahpur village, adjacent to GIFT City, 65-year-old farmer Ganesh Vaghela paints a contrasting picture on the jobs front. "Locals are unemployed, while outsiders have got jobs in GIFT City," he rues, sitting outside the gram panchayat office. "Even educated youths only find temporary, blue-collar work earning Rs 10,000-20,000 monthly." While claiming his village will still vote for the BJP, Vaghela says the government must act faster on jobs and inflation. Even as a similar sentiment is echoed elsewhere too, Shah insists there is no dearth of jobs anywhere in the country, let alone in Gandhinagar. "The government has set up multiple ITIs (industrial training institutes). A mini ITI has come up in Sanand as well to equip local youth with industry-specific skills.... There are ample job opportunities for those willing to work," he tells INDIA TODAY (*see accompanying interview*).

The BJP's confidence is bolstered by the perceived lack of a formidable contest in Gandhinagar. Sonal Patel, a 62-year-old architect and All India Congress Committee (AICC) secretary, is the candidate representing the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA). In the past, the Congress had made unsuccessful attempts to breach this saffron bastion by fielding high-profile nominees like actor Rajesh Khanna (1996 bypoll) and former election commissioner T.N. Seshan (1999). Its 2019 candidate, grassroots leader C.J. Chavda, who secured 337,610 votes against Shah's 894,624, defected to the BJP last



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

"THERE ARE AMPLE JOBS FOR THOSE WILLING TO WORK"

Amid a gruelling day of road shows and rallies in Gandhinagar, Union home minister Amit Shah took a brief respite to sit down for a freewheeling chat with Senior Associate Editor Jumana Shah. Dismissing unemployment as a non-issue and voicing confidence in the BJP leadership's ability to placate the protesting Kshatriyas, Shah says voters in his constituency remain committed to backing PM Narendra Modi. Excerpts:

Q. What are the key issues in Gandhinagar?

A. There are no issues left here. Strengthening Prime Minister Narendra Modi's hand is the only agenda. Gandhinagar is a highly developed constituency. It has the bullet train (the upcoming Mumbai-Ahmedabad high-speed rail corridor) and metro rail connectivity, the world's largest cricket stadium (Narendra Modi Stadium) and GIFT City (India's first and only International Financial Services Centre). We have made a lot of effort to ensure all government schemes are implemented here effectively. There is not a single village that does not get round-the-clock electricity supply. No household is without an LPG connection or drinking water or ration card. All schemes are saturated here.

Q. The Kshatriya protests are refusing to subside and have in fact spread across the state. How will it impact the BJP?

A. We are talking to the community... they are with us and I am confident that they will not vote against the BJP. Discussions are under way and a resolution will emerge soon.

Q. The BJP witnessed internal protests on half a dozen seats when the candidates were announced. How will that affect the party's prospects?

A. Workers may have some differences of opinion, but everybody understands that strengthening